

Myliobatis aquila

Common eagle ray

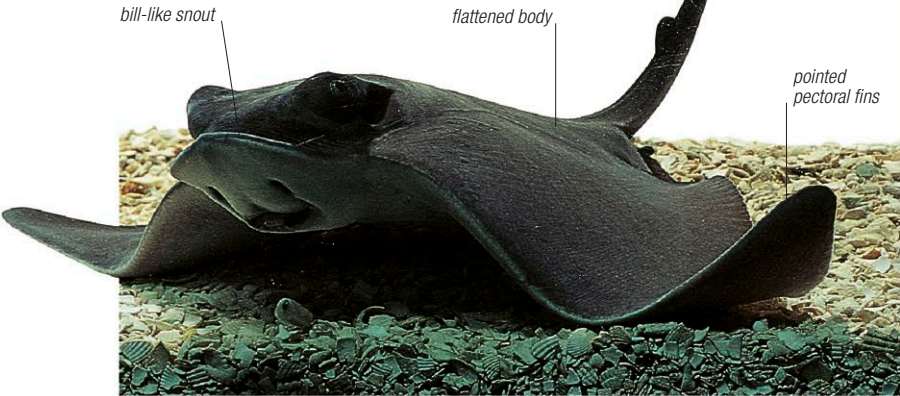


Length 8¼ ft (2.5 m) or more
Weight 44–66 lb (20–30 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Data deficient

Location E. Atlantic, Mediterranean, S.W. Indian Ocean

The common eagle ray has tapered pectoral fins, a blunt snout, and an exceptionally long tail armed with a venomous spine. The body of this fish varies in color from grayish brown to bronze or blackish, and its mouth, positioned on its underside, is equipped

with a massive, crushing toothplate. Like its numerous relatives, which are found in oceans all over the world, it feeds on the seabed, but is equally at home in open water. The common eagle ray feeds on a wide variety of small animals, and it excavates these from the sediment by flapping its fins, or by blowing jets of water to clear away mud and sand. A good swimmer, the common eagle ray can leap clear of the water's surface to escape attack from predators. Female common eagle rays give birth to 3–7 live young each year.



Pristis pectinata

Smalltooth sawfish

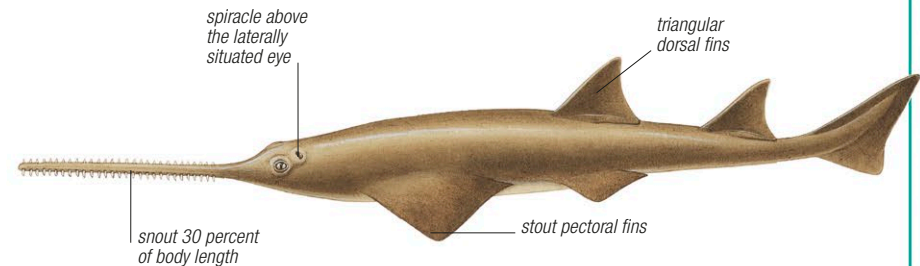


Length 20 ft (6 m) or more
Weight 550–660 lb (250–300 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Critically endangered

Location W. and E. Atlantic, Indo-Pacific

Also known as the wide sawfish, this long-bodied fish has a remarkable snout, which is about one-quarter of its body length and has 24–32 pairs of pointed teeth on either side. Although it is equipped with this sawlike snout, it is not generally aggressive and is dangerous only if mishandled by divers. The smalltooth sawfish has a flattened head with small eyes, which have spiracles situated above and slightly posterior to them. The mouth and gill

slits are located on the underside of the head. While typically found in the shallow, sandy, and muddy water of beaches and bays, the smalltooth sawfish may occasionally be found at the mouth of rivers and freshwater streams. It feeds by patrolling the seabed and sucking up small organisms, sometimes using the saw to probe the bottom or excavate buried prey. It also slashes into schools of fishes with its sawlike snout, feeding on dead or maimed fishes that fall to the bottom. The female gives birth to 15–20 young, which are born with a protective membrane over their saws, an adaptation that protects the female while giving birth. At first, the young live in nursery areas, which are usually found in shallow water where there is plenty of vegetation. Loss of these areas due to coastal development has contributed to their decline. One of 6 similar species, the smalltooth sawfish is subject to overfishing in many areas because its flesh is edible and the saw is sold as a souvenir.



Potamotrygon motoro

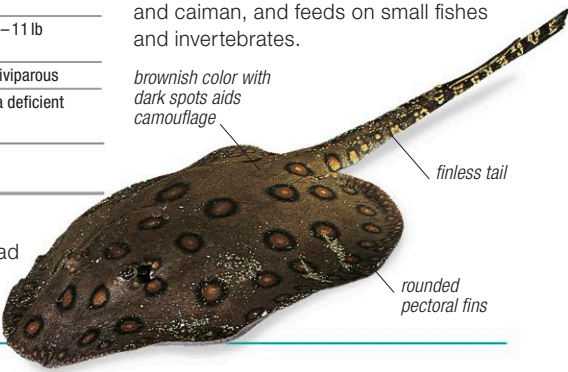
South American freshwater stingray



Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight 6½–11 lb (3–5 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Data deficient

Location South America

This round-bodied ray is the most common and widespread freshwater stingray in South America. It is a member of



an entire family of stingrays that evolved in freshwater from a marine ancestor. The short tail of the South American freshwater stingray has no fin, and its small pelvic fins are tucked under its pectoral fins. This stingray has few predators, except some larger fishes and caiman, and feeds on small fishes and invertebrates.

Torpedo marmorata

Marbled electric ray

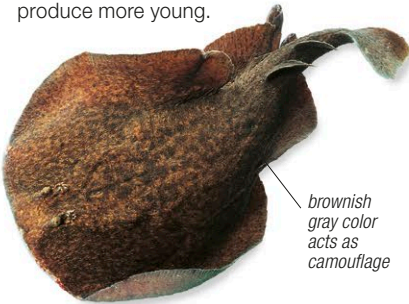


Length Up to 3¼ in (1 m)
Weight 22–29 lb (10–13 kg)
Breeding Viviparous
Status Data deficient

Location E. Atlantic, Mediterranean

Many cartilaginous fishes use weak electrical signals to detect prey, but this ray can generate shocks, powerful enough to kill other fishes, from specially modified gill muscles at the base of its

pectoral fins. Although such shocks are not known to be fatal to humans, contact with this ray can be dangerous. Active during the day and in the evening, the marbled electric ray generally lies on the ocean floor, well camouflaged against the sediment. Females give birth to 5–35 young every year; larger females produce more young.



Hydrolagus collieri

Spotted ratfish



Length Up to 37 in (95 cm)
Weight 4½–13 lb (2–6 kg)
Breeding Oviparous
Status Least concern

Location E. North Pacific

Ratfishes are found in deep water in most parts of the world, but the spotted ratfish is one of only 2 species that live on the Pacific coast of North America. Like other ratfishes, it has a disproportionately large head, and a downward-facing mouth that is

equipped with large, crushing teeth, and scaleless, slippery skin. Males have a retractable, clublike appendage between their eyes, which is used to grip with during mating. Adults are usually dark brown or grayish, with green, yellow, or bluish hues, and they have silvery white spots along their sides. Spotted ratfishes are slow swimmers, and rely on a venomous dorsal spine as their main defense against attack. They patrol the ocean floor in search of prey, feeding on invertebrates and seabed fishes. Females usually lay 2–5 eggs a year; each one is contained in a long, spindle-shaped case. Ratfish liver contains an oil that was once used as a machine and gun lubricant, but is today of little commercial value.

